

Weekly Reading Reflections #3: Sergio Monterroso

Project Research Week

Col. William P. Pierce

Price is the original founder of the University of North Georgia and has a very rich history in the Dahlonega area for his charitable services to education. The application to place Price's home on the National Register of Historic Places paints a very positive picture of Pierce, citing: his donation of land for a Black school in 1867, the founding of the North Georgia Agricultural College, and his service to the community by donating money to the college to ensure its success and to local community faith groups in their times of need. Members of the community still have a great look on Pierce as he's become somewhat of a local deity in terms of the already-rich history of Dahlonega and North Georgia at-large.

Unfortunately, as is the case with most old White men in early American history, there is an unmentioned history that, in this case, works against the prevailing narrative that Pierce was a philanthropist with a heart of gold. Pierce had to lie to his fellow legislators that North Georgians "were as a class, loyal to the Union during the Civil War, that, in the main, they were of the purest Revolutionary stock, and that it was largely for the purpose of educating the children of these mountaineers"¹ that North Georgia needed a college. The reality is starkly different, even Pierce himself was a confederate soldier and would champion the Southern cause in Congress.² Pierce would gift confederate memorabilia to the college³ and engage in memorial events involving the Daughters of the Confederacy⁴, who he was intimately connected with and allowed them to use the college as their place of business. Newspapers called Pierce "an enthusiastic veteran of the lost cause, and loses no opportunity to preserve its traditions."⁵

Even the historian that signed off on the application to add Pierce's house to the registry was silent on this, most locals are. How do you confront the ugly truth of someone that is deified in the halls of Dahlonega's history? It's difficult, and some prefer to stay silent on it — as we've learned in this class as being frequently the case. In other cases, there are political ramifications to acknowledge that your college's founder had pushed the provision in state law that called for segregated schooling.⁶

Gen. James Longstreet

General James Longstreet was a Confederate general with strategic prowess that earned him a nickname from Robert E. Lee, who referred to Longstreet as his war horse. After the war, Longstreet became a Reconstruction Republican who worked closely with the federal government after the Confederacy's defeat, which angered many Southerners.

¹ G. R. Glenn, "William Pierce Price," in *Men of Mark in Georgia*, ed. William J. Northen (Atlanta, GA: A. B. Caldwell, 1908), 125-126.

² Glenn, 127.

³ "Gift to the College," *Dahlonega Nugget* (Dahlonega, GA), Oct. 14, 1904.

⁴ "Dahlonega's Memorial," *Dahlonega Nugget* (Dahlonega, GA), Apr. 30, 1904.

⁵ "Gift to the College," *Dahlonega Nugget*.

⁶ Lucian Lamar Knight, *Georgia's Landmarks, Memorials and Legends*, vol. 1 (Atlanta, GA: The Byrd Printing Company, 1913), 756-7.

After the war, newspapers gave heavy rebukes of Longstreet saying that he “aligned himself with a party which is bitterly antagonistic to everything southern and to all southern interests.”⁷ Lost Cause ideologues began using Longstreet as a focal point to their historical revisionism, claiming that his incompetence at Gettysburg was the reason that the confederates were handed a sounding defeat which eventually led to the surrender at Appomattox. His critics “appeared to be committed to a particular conclusion, and were intent on shaping it and preserve it for the historical record.”⁸ Other confederate leaders at the time were quick to defend Longstreet, saying that “the imputations upon his loyalty to the South are simply ridiculous.”⁹

Longstreet remains largely forgotten in Southern history, even left out in monuments like Stone Mountain in his home state of Georgia. Followers of Longstreet’s history characterize his story as “marginalized, and unnoticed until a closer examination is made.”¹⁰ In our class, Longstreet is a prime example of how historical narratives are weapons to political causes and that museums, through slight incorporation of his smaller voice, can change history. I had never heard of Longstreet, but had heard of Jefferson Davis, Lee, etc. Now, my view of civil war history has changed

Cool Notes, Don’t Fit Paper Though

- NGAC took fifty years to admit female students – North Georgia Journal // Spring 1998 ed.
- The wife of Prof. Gaillard (who Gaillard Hall is named after) was President of the Daughters of the Confederacy – Dahlonga Nugget.

⁷ “General Longstreet Marries Miss Dortch,” *Waycross Herald* (Waycross, GA), Sept. 11, 1897.

⁸ Harold M. Knudsen, Introduction to *General James Longstreet: The Confederacy’s Most Modern General* (Girard, IL: USA Publishing Services, 2007), xvii.

⁹ “Gen. James Longstreet: Gen D. H. Hill, in his ‘Southern Home,’” *Bainbridge Weekly Democrat* (Bainbridge, GA), Aug. 12, 1875.

¹⁰ Knudsen, viii.